

The Second Larut War Reconsidered: A Frontier Crisis Beyond the Gambling Narrative

A Historical Reconsideration Based on Contemporaneous Colonial Correspondence

By Ho Siew Khui 何小驹 (Hé Xiǎojū)

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Abstract

This study re-examines the later historical narrative commonly described as the “Second Larut War” using Colonial Office and Straits Settlements correspondence from the mid-1860s.

The records examined for this study describe attacks on mining settlements, burning of houses, organised violence, deaths, refugee movements into Province Wellesley and major disruption to mining and trade within Larut.

The documents also reveal deeper underlying tensions behind the violence. Long before the fighting reached its peak, Larut was already facing commercial rivalry, competing creditor interests, disputes over tin ownership, unstable authority and growing tension within the mining districts.

Later historical narratives commonly associate the conflict with a gambling dispute. However, the Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study instead points toward a mining frontier already strained by commercial rivalry, disputed ownership claims, competing financial interests and unstable authority before large-scale violence erupted in 1865.

Keywords: Second Larut War; Larut Disturbances; Law Sam; Cheng Siang; Hwe-Chu; Tin Mining; Commercial Rivalry; Frontier Conflict; Perak; Colonial Office Records; CO 273/15; Nineteenth-Century Malaya.

Introduction

The Second Larut War is commonly described in later historical writing as a gambling dispute between rival Chinese groups that escalated into violence within the Larut mining districts during 1865. Some later narratives also state that Lew Ah Sam was called in to mediate the dispute before the fighting intensified.¹

The individual commonly referred to in later historical narratives as ‘Lew Ah Sam’ appears under several transliteration variants including ‘Law Sam,’ ‘Lau Sam’ and ‘Low Ah Sam’ in historical and public reference materials.

The historian Wong Choon San, author of *A Gallery of Chinese Kapitans* (1964), identified Low Sam as 劉道清 (Liú Dàoqīng) in his annotations to the Petition of Chung Ah Quee and Others. Although the original Chinese signature sheet has not been located by the present author, Wong’s identification appears to have been based upon a contemporaneous petition signature and presently constitutes the strongest published evidence linking Low Sam with the Chinese name 劉道清 (Liú Dàoqīng).²

This study revisits that narrative using Colonial Office and Straits Settlements correspondence contained mainly within CO 273/15 held by The National Archives, Kew, United Kingdom.

The purpose of this study is not to dispute that major violence occurred in Larut during 1865. The surviving records leave little doubt that serious disturbances took place involving attacks on mining settlements, burning of houses, deaths, expulsions and disruption to mining and trade.

However, the Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study does not identify gambling as the principal cause of the wider disturbances at Klian Poh and Klian Baru. Nor do the records contain evidence that Lew Ah Sam personally mediated the dispute.

The correspondence examined during this study does, however, contain a contemporaneous affidavit identifying Law Sam as one of the leaders of the Cheng Siang Chinese during the disturbances of 1865. While this evidence places him directly within the leadership structure of one of the principal factions involved in the conflict, it does not indicate that he acted as a mediator.

Instead, the correspondence points toward a mining frontier already strained by commercial rivalry, competing creditor interests, disputed ownership claims, unstable authority and growing tension within the mining districts before large-scale violence erupted in 1865.

The disturbances appear more closely tied to struggles over mining control and commercial interests than to a simple gambling quarrel.

Sources and Methodology

This study is based primarily on Colonial Office and Straits Settlements correspondence contained within CO 273/15 held by The National Archives, Kew, United Kingdom. The records were accessed through Gale Primary Sources.

The material examined includes official correspondence, petitions, affidavits, commercial claims and supporting schedules relating to disturbances within the Larut mining districts during 1865 and 1866.

The study also examines selected later historical works and published historical sources, including Khoo Kay Kim's *The Western Malay States 1850–1873*, Wong Choon San's *A Gallery of Chinese Kapitans*, Wilfred Blythe's *The Impact of Chinese Secret Societies in Malaya: A Historical Study* (1969), C. D. Cowan's edited publication of Sir Frank Swettenham's *Perak Journals, 1874–1876*, and Mervyn Llewelyn Wynne's *Triad and Tabut* (1941). Particular attention has been given to Wynne's original treatment of the Second Larut War in order to compare his account directly with surviving contemporaneous Colonial Office correspondence and to distinguish Wynne's own interpretation from the manner in which it has subsequently been summarised or interpreted in later historiography.

While these later sources provide important historiographical context, this study focuses principally on contemporaneous documentary evidence produced during or shortly after the disturbances themselves. Particular attention has been given to descriptions of violence, commercial disputes, mining finance, seizure of tin, refugee movements and questions of authority within Larut.

The purpose of this study is not to reject later historiography entirely but to compare later narratives against surviving contemporaneous records examined during this study. Where later historical interpretations differ from the surviving Colonial Office correspondence, priority has been given to the contemporaneous material.

The present study's direct examination of Wynne's original 1941 text suggests that his treatment of the Second Larut War was more measured and nuanced than is often reflected in later summaries. Although Wynne recounted the frequently repeated narrative concerning Lee Ah Kun, the alleged affair and subsequent killing, his wider discussion placed the disturbances within a broader context of commercial rivalry, political tension, mining interests and secret-society conflict rather than attributing the violence to a single dramatic incident.

Researchers should note that Gale Primary Sources image numbering may differ from original Colonial Office folio numbering or archival pagination.

The Gambling Narrative and Frontier Instability

The Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study does not identify gambling as the principal cause of the wider disturbances at Klian Poh and Klian Baru.

Most modern summaries describe the “Second Larut War” as a gambling dispute between rival Chinese groups that escalated into violence. Some later narratives also state that Lew Ah Sam was called in to mediate the dispute.

One source sometimes cited in connection with the gambling narrative is Frank Swettenham's journal of February 1874. During a river expedition in Perak, Swettenham recorded an account related to him by Ah Yam, whom Swettenham identified elsewhere in the journal as the Chinese Commissioner representing the Si Quans and who corresponds with Chin Ah Yam, the Ghee Hin representative involved in the Larut settlement. The narrative described a gambling-table dispute said to have occurred about ten years earlier, followed by the capture and execution of Huy Chew men by means of sharpened bamboo and subsequent retaliatory violence. However, Swettenham was not an eyewitness to these events. The account was recorded approximately nine years after the disturbances and appears to have been related by a participant associated with one side of the conflict. While the narrative demonstrates that stories linking the 1865 disturbances to a gambling quarrel and bamboo executions were circulating in Larut by 1874, it constitutes interested testimony rather than independent corroboration and should therefore be treated with appropriate caution.³

Taken together, the correspondence points toward a mining frontier already under pressure from commercial rivalry, competing creditor interests, disputes over tin ownership and unstable authority before the violence reached its peak.

The Second Larut War therefore appears less as a sudden gambling dispute that unexpectedly escalated into violence and more as the eruption of tensions already building within an unstable mining frontier shaped by commercial rivalry, competing financial interests, factional conflict and weak political authority.

One of the better-known later narratives associated with the gambling-dispute explanation concerns the alleged killing of Lee Ah Kun, which has frequently been presented as the result of an affair that precipitated wider conflict between rival secret-society factions. This later narrative was also examined through a direct reading of Wynne's *Triad and Tabut*, which suggests a more complex interpretation than is sometimes conveyed in later summaries. While Wynne recounted the traditional narrative concerning Lee Ah Kun, he also questioned an important element of that account, observing that the alleged "intrigue with the wife of a near relative of Chang Keng Kwi" was "difficult to accept as genuine". Instead, he discussed the episode within the wider context of Triad–Tokong rivalry and conditions prevailing in the Larut mining districts.⁴

The present examination of Wynne's original text likewise found no contemporaneous evidence supporting the frequently repeated account that Law Sam personally mediated the dispute prior to the outbreak of large-scale violence. Wynne's narrative should therefore be read alongside the surviving Colonial Office correspondence rather than treated as contemporaneous evidence in itself.

An Unstable Mining Frontier

The correspondence examined within CO 273/15 suggests that Larut was already unstable before the major clashes of 1865.⁵

The petitions and correspondence contain repeated complaints involving commercial disputes, seizure of tin, debt recovery problems, disputed ownership claims and accusations against local authorities. Several petitions describe merchants being unable to recover payment for tin already purchased or financed. Other complaints involved confiscation of ore and interference with commercial arrangements.

British correspondence also referred to “disturbances,” “anarchy” and continuing insecurity within Larut.⁶ In several places, the records suggest that authority within the mining districts was weak, divided or contested.

Much of the mining economy depended upon advances from Penang merchants who supplied rice, provisions and capital in exchange for future tin production.⁷ This created overlapping financial obligations, competing creditor claims and tension over ownership of mining output.

The Fighting at Klian Poh and Klian Baru

The affidavits and petitions leave little doubt that serious violence took place during 1865.

These petitions and affidavits describe attacks on mining settlements at Klian Poh and Klian Baru. Houses were burnt and plundered. Mining establishments were destroyed. Tin and ore were seized. People were killed and large numbers of miners and villagers were forced to flee.⁸

One affidavit described a quarrel between Hwe-Chu and Cheng Siang miners which led to “several conflicts” in which houses were burnt, property was plundered and lives were lost.⁹

The same statement added that a temporary truce and attempted compromise were later arranged between the opposing groups, although the records do not identify any formal mediator or authority responsible for enforcing the arrangement.¹⁰

The truce did not last. Armed Malays together with Chinese forces allegedly attacked Hwe-Chu settlements at Klian Baru. About 2,000 inhabitants were reportedly expelled after killings, burnings and destruction of property.¹¹

Several statements also described refugees fleeing through the jungle toward Province Wellesley in conditions of hunger, exhaustion and injury. Some reportedly died during the journey.¹²

Following the collapse of the truce, the fighting was accompanied by seizure of property, confiscation of tin and displacement of rival groups from mining areas. This strongly suggests that control over mining settlements and tin production formed an important part of the wider struggle.

The violence described above cannot be separated from the commercial disputes and competing financial interests that repeatedly appear throughout the same correspondence.

Law Sam and the Cheng Siang Leadership

One contemporaneous affidavit provides important evidence concerning the role of Law Sam during the disturbances. In a sworn declaration dated 18 October 1865, Jibon Ali, a former Larut government officer, stated that Che Lamat and Che Kulup Ma Ali "took an oath to the leaders of the Cheng Siang Chinese named Law Sam, Akwee Kayah and Kuan Kui" concerning assistance to the Cheng Siang Chinese during the conflict.¹³

This statement identifies Law Sam as one of the recognised leaders of the Cheng Siang Chinese during the disturbances of 1865. The affidavit is significant because it provides contemporaneous evidence of his leadership role rather than relying upon later historical narratives.

At the same time, the affidavit does not describe Law Sam as a mediator, nor does it associate him with any gambling dispute. Instead, it places him within the leadership structure of one of the principal factions involved in the conflict.

Later historical research by Wong Choon San identified Low Sam as 劉道清 (Liú Dàoqīng). In Appendix K of *A Gallery of Chinese Kapitans*, Wong associated this name with a signature appearing on the Petition of Chung Ah Quee and Others. As the facsimile edition reproduces only the English text of the petition and not the original Chinese signatures, independent verification remains desirable. Nevertheless, Wong's observation presently provides the strongest published link between Law Sam of the Colonial Office correspondence and the Chinese name 劉道清 (Liú Dàoqīng).

Mining Wealth and Commercial Control

The correspondence repeatedly returns to disputes involving mining wealth and commercial control.

A large portion of the correspondence involved ownership disputes, seizure of tin, competing creditor claims and recovery of commercial losses.¹⁴ Supporting schedules attached to petitions listed hundreds of slabs of tin and more than a thousand pikuls of ore allegedly lost during the disturbances.¹⁵

Petitions submitted by Oh Wee Kee described how Penang merchants financed mining operations in Larut through advances of rice, provisions and capital.¹⁶ The same records also referred to disputes over who held the “first right” to future tin production.

Several petitions further alleged that tin belonging to merchants or miners was confiscated, diverted or wrongfully appropriated during the disturbances.¹⁷

Taken together, the records suggest that economic control over mining production formed an important underlying dimension of the conflict.

The Lew Ah Sam Mediation Narrative

However, the surviving Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study does not contain evidence that Lew Ah Sam personally mediated the dispute.

One affidavit does identify Law Sam as one of the leaders of the Cheng Siang Chinese during the disturbances. This demonstrates his involvement in the events of 1865 and confirms his position within the Cheng Siang leadership. Nevertheless, the affidavit contains no suggestion that he acted as a mediator between the opposing factions.

Conclusion

The records examined during this study show that serious disturbances took place within Larut during 1865. The violence involved attacks on mining settlements, burning of houses, deaths, refugee movements and disruption to mining and trade.

However, the Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study does not identify gambling as the principal cause of the wider disturbances at Klian Poh and Klian Baru.

Instead, the documents point toward a mining frontier already strained by commercial rivalry, competing financial interests, disputed ownership claims and unstable authority before large-scale violence erupted in 1865.

The Colonial Office correspondence examined during this study also contains no record of Lew Ah Sam acting as mediator in a gambling dispute connected to the outbreak of the disturbances.

At the same time, the correspondence does contain contemporaneous evidence identifying Law Sam as one of the leaders of the Cheng Siang Chinese during the disturbances. This confirms his direct involvement in the events of 1865, although not in the role of mediator described in some later accounts.

Taken together, the surviving records suggest that the Second Larut War emerged from wider struggles over mining control, commercial rivalry and unstable frontier conditions rather than from a simple gambling dispute.

The surviving contemporaneous correspondence likewise contains no evidence corroborating the frequently repeated account of Lee Ah Kun's alleged affair or death by pig-cage execution. While such traditions may preserve elements of historical events, the dramatic circumstances traditionally associated with them remain insufficiently supported by contemporaneous evidence and should therefore be treated with caution.

This study also found that a direct examination of Wynne's *Triad and Tabut* presents a more nuanced interpretation than is often reflected in later summaries. Rather than reducing the conflict to a single gambling dispute or dramatic personal incident, Wynne situated the disturbances within a wider framework of commercial rivalry, political tension and secret-society conflict. Reconsidering Wynne in his own words therefore helps distinguish his original interpretation from later simplifications while reinforcing the importance of contemporaneous Colonial Office correspondence as the principal evidential basis for reconstructing the events of 1865.

Researched and authored by

Ho Siew Khui 何小駒 (Hé Xiǎojū)

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End Notes

1. See Khoo Kay Kim, *The Western Malay States 1850–1873: The Effects of Commercial Development on Malay Politics* (Kuala Lumpur: Oxford University Press, 1972), p. 136.

The gambling-dispute narrative also appears in later historical overviews and public reference works, including the Wikipedia entry “Second Larut War”:

https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Second_Larut_War&oldid=1353989582

(accessed 27 May 2026).

2. Wong Choon San, *A Gallery of Chinese Kapitans* (Singapore: Donald Moore, 1964; facsimile reprint, George Town: Areca Books, 2024), Appendix K, note 5(b), p.125. Wong identified Low Sam as 劉道清 (Liú Dàoqīng) based on the signature appearing on the Petition of Chung Ah Quee and Others reproduced in Appendix H.

3. Frank Swettenham, "Journal, February 1874," in C. D. Cowan (ed.), *Sir Frank Swettenham's Perak Journals, 1874–1876*, *Journal of the Malayan Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society*, Vol. 25, Pt. 4 (1952), pp. 10, 40–42. Swettenham identified Ah Yam as the Chinese Commissioner representing the Si Quans during the expedition. This identification corresponds with Chin Ah Yam, the Ghee Hin representative involved in the Larut settlement. The account formed part of a wider narrative concerning the complaint made by the widow of Soh Ah Tseang and included a gambling dispute, bamboo executions and subsequent retaliatory violence. Swettenham was not an eyewitness to the alleged events, which were said to have occurred approximately ten years earlier.

4. L. H. Wynne, *Triad and Tabut: A Survey of the Origin and Diffusion of Chinese and Mohamedan Secret Societies in the Malay Peninsula, 1800–1935* (Singapore: Government Printer, 1941), pp. 266, 276. Wynne recounted the traditional narrative concerning the killing of Lee Ah Kun (p. 266) but later observed that the alleged "intrigue with the wife of a near relative of Chang Keng Kwi" was "difficult to accept as genuine" (p. 276). He reasoned that "the trade in women was part and parcel of the Triad-Tokong system", that Chinese miners seldom brought wives from China, and that the episode was more plausibly understood within the wider context of the Triad–Tokong vendetta than as the primary cause of the conflict. The present study included a direct examination of the original 1941 edition.

5. British Colonial Office Records, CO 273/15 and related Straits Settlements correspondence, 1865–1866, The National Archives, Kew, United Kingdom, accessed through Gale Primary Sources.

6. CO 273/15, pp. 636, 654, 661. Correspondence referring to disturbances, insecurity and instability within Larut.

7. CO 273/15, pp. 664–665. Statements concerning merchant advances, mining finance and future rights over tin production.

8. CO 273/15, pp. 701–702. Affidavits and petitions concerning attacks on mining settlements at Klian Poh and Klian Baru.
9. CO 273/15, p. 701. Affidavit describing conflicts between Hwe-Chu and Cheng Siang miners involving burning, plundering and deaths. (The Hwe-Chu miners were aligned with the Ghee Hin Society, while the Cheng Siang miners were aligned with the Hai San Society).
10. CO 273/15, p. 701. Statement referring to a temporary truce and attempted compromise between opposing groups.
11. CO 273/15, pp. 701–702. Statements alleging attacks upon Hwe-Chu settlements and expulsion of inhabitants from Klian Baru.
12. CO 273/15, p. 702. Statements concerning fugitives fleeing through the jungle toward Province Wellesley following the disturbances.
13. CO 273/15, p. 717. Affidavit of Jibon Ali, dated 18 October 1865. Jibon Ali stated that Che Lamat and Che Kulup Ma Ali "took an oath to the leaders of the Cheng Siang Chinese named Law Sam, Akwee Kayah and Kuan Kui." The affidavit identifies Law Sam as one of the recognised leaders of the Cheng Siang Chinese during the disturbances of 1865.
14. CO 273/15, pp. 637–639; pp. 661–664. Commercial petitions concerning creditor claims, ownership disputes and recovery of losses.
15. CO 273/15, p. 703. Schedules quantifying alleged losses of tin and ore following attacks on mining settlements.
16. CO 273/15, pp. 700–703. Statement of Oh Wee Kee concerning financing arrangements for mining operations in Larut.
17. CO 273/15, pp. 638–640; p. 714. Petitions relating to confiscation, resale, diversion and alleged wrongful appropriation of tin during the Larut disturbances.